



Language development and the **development of communication skills**, is part of cognitive development – using the brain for thinking, listening and talking and using language for learning through reading and writing.

Language development is dependent on the other developmental domains. The ability to communicate with others grows from infancy, but children develop these abilities at different rates. Aspects of language include;

- **Phonology:** Creating the sounds of speech
- **Pragmatics:** Communicating verbally and non-verbally in social situations
- **Semantics:** Understanding the rules of what words mean
- **Syntax:** Using grammar and putting sentences together

One of the most important things you can do with your child throughout their early life is to read to them and not just at bedtime. Make reading and enjoying books a central part of your day.

Reading out loud to your kids from birth and beyond has a major impact on their emerging language and literacy skills.

Aside from reading books, look for opportunities to read other things, too, like the directions to a board game, letters from family members, holiday cards, online articles, and school newsletters. Hearing new vocabulary words spoken expands a child's vocabulary and helps them prepare to identify unfamiliar words when used in context.

In addition to reading, make sure you are talking to your kids even before they can say their first word. Tell them about the things you are doing or what you're buying in the store. Point out different things and engage them in the world around them. Singing to your child is another excellent way to build your child's language skills.

As they get older, try holding regular conversations, answering questions, and asking for your child's ideas or opinions. All of these activities are an important part of their language development.

WAYS TO SUPPORT LANGUAGE DEVELOPMENT.

- **Use Comments**

You will be exposing children to richer language and helping them to learn new words when you use comments during your interactions with them.

Talk about what children are interested in at the time they are interested in it. Use specific labels (say “I like your car” rather than “I like that”).

Model good spoken language yourself. Remember to add a word or an idea to what the child has said to really help extend their language learning.

- **Ask fewer questions**

Lots of questions can put pressure on children to communicate. It may feel like a test and can quickly stop the flow of the conversation. Try the 4 to 1 ratio – for every question you ask, try to make 4 comments.

- **Wait**

If you use a question or a comment, WAIT for the child's response before jumping in with more of your own words.

You might need to wait expectantly for as long as 10 seconds before you get a response. Learning to talk is a complex process, and when children are still learning it can take a bit longer for them to process what you've said and respond.

- **Be at the child's level**

This might mean being physically face to face at their level but also cognitively.

Using language at the right developmental level and keeping the interaction at the child's pace will really help keep to conversation going.

You may need to simplify your language to be at the child's level or one step higher – if the child is speaking in 3- or 4-word sentences, try to speak in sentences of around 3 to 5 words yourself.

- **Take Turns**

Research studies show that lots of turn-taking in conversations with babies and children stimulates the language center in the brain.

A good conversation looks like a game of tennis where each person takes a turn, and you keep it going as long as you can (serve and return). The more turns the better!

- **Repeat, Repeat, Repeat**

Words, songs, stories... there is no such thing as too much repetition for children.

Repetition is great for language learning; children need to hear new words lots of times in many different situations for them to be securely stored in their word bank or lexicon.

- **Make any time a talking time**

Making time for talk can be challenging in busy, free-flow play environments. Care routines, like nappy changing and handwashing can easily be times for communication too. Just use the strategies above to encourage talk while going about daily routines with children. Prioritizing time for talk in small groups is also important and using picture books with no words encourages children to talk and explore their imagination by developing their own ideas, let them do the talking.